

Diploma in Leadership & Management

Adaptive leadership



Contents

- 3 Lesson outcomes
- 3 Adaptive leadership
- 9 References



Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of being an adaptive manager and leader. Students will gain a better understanding when it comes to adaptive leadership and how to improve and use this key skill.

Introduction

Adaptive Leadership is a practical leadership framework that helps individuals and organisations adapt and thrive in challenging environments. It is being able, both individually and collectively, to take on the gradual but meaningful process of change. (Cambridge-leadership)

Key reading materials:

- The Practice of Adaptive Leadership: Tools and Tactics for Changing Your Organization and the World
- Leadership on the Line: Staying Alive Through the Dangers of Leading
- Get on the Balcony

Adaptive leadership:

According to (Villanovau, n.d.) these key analyses provided by we see the following break-down of adaptive leadership.

Adaptive leadership is the key to unlocking a company's potential. Business executives who want to excel as leaders can face many challenges in both set ambitious goals and motivating employees to meet them.

Adaptive leadership offers a practical path to solving business issues while challenging the traditional systems that have dominated many organizations for decades.

Leaders who practice and adaptive style can learn to separate important aspects of a business operation from what can be discarded. By focusing on the value-added to the business rather than traditional hierarchy, they learn to identify and capitalize on smart risks while avoiding wasteful distractions.



Key Points of Adaptive Leadership



The thinking behind adaptive leadership evolved over three decades of study at Harvard University by Ron Heifetz and Marty Linsky. The two researched the cutting edge of innovative management training and development. The development of the practice focused on a business landscape that had become global in nature and where change proved both inevitable and rapid. The duo wanted a leadership management approach that equipped leaders to motivate workers to tackle tough challenges.

People who use adaptive leadership tend to see organizations not as mechanical, rigid structures but as systems where everyone constantly interacts and impacts each other. As the business climate changes, so must employees, business processes and leadership's approach.

Adaptive Leadership vs. Traditional Methods



In practice, adaptive leadership focuses more on leadership as a practice than as a position. For a manager using adaptive leadership, situations constantly evolve and require both flexibility and innovation.

Here are some of the areas where adaptive leadership differs in approach to more traditional management.

- Job duties for employees remain broad-based, allowing for flexibility, as opposed to detailed, ironclad job duty lists.
- Roles within an organization are fluid – for example, one person can fill in for another if a situation warrants. This approach differs from static job duties for employees.
- Communications are open and employees are encouraged to form their own networks to facilitate better sharing of information, as opposed to controlled communication from the top down.
- Policies encourage people to innovate and find solutions, as opposed to rules that provide strict guidelines on what employees can and cannot do.
- Organizational structures are temporary and fluid to meet the immediate situation, as opposed to bureaucratic and regimented departments that work separately.
- While a ranking structure is in place, influence is granted to people who demonstrate an ability to add value to a product or process, as opposed to a top-down management structure.

Adaptive leadership characteristics



(Indeed, n.d.) provides the following insight into Adaptive leaders. Adaptive leaders consistently demonstrate a group of characteristics. Remember, in an adaptive leadership model, any member of the organization can be a leader. These characteristics can be developed over time. If you are interested in implementing adaptive leadership, model these characteristics:

- Goal-oriented**:** Adaptive leaders link systematic change to long-term organizational goals. Action is taken with a specific result in mind.

- Open-minded: Adaptive leaders create an open-minded and progressive environment in which to work. Mistakes are accepted as part of the process.
- Appreciative of challenges: Adaptive leaders understand the challenge. They prepare their team members for problem-solving. Adaptive leaders understand that reaching a long-term solution may take several attempts.
- Committed: Adaptive leaders know that change takes time, and they are ready to commit the necessary time to create a better organization.
- Proactive: Adaptive leaders take a proactive approach. They identify challenges and invest whatever resources are needed ahead of time to solve them.
- Embracing uncertainty: Adaptive leaders embrace uncertainty. They know that not having an immediate answer to a problem is part of the process of positive change.
- Experimental: Adaptive leaders are experimenters. They are prepared to reflect on their work and redirect as needed. They understand that tackling vague, complex issues requires trial and error.
- Emotionally aware: Adaptive leaders are as concerned with relationships as they are profits. That understanding helps them ensure that organizational members and other stakeholders are supportive of any long-term changes.

References

- Villanovau. (n.d.). How Adaptive Leadership Leads to Business Success. Retrieved from Villanovau: <https://www.villanovau.com/resources/leadership/adaptive-leadership/>
 - Indeed. (n.d.). Adaptive leadership . Retrieved from Indeed: <https://www.indeed.com/career-advice/career-development/adaptive-leadership>
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